

08

The Headline Word Palette

Document 8 of 8 · Reference tool

If you're new to this series, start with ****What a Headline Actually Does****.

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How to Use This Palette

Draft first, palette second. This is a revision tool, not a starting point. Write your headline from the idea out — benefit, angle, curiosity gap — and *then* bring it here: swap vague words for grounded context words, and check that your emotional vocabulary fits your surface's budget. A headline assembled word-by-word from any list reads like it was, and the pre-conscious hype filter catches it.

Two categories, two jobs. **Context words** set the *environment* — they anchor your message in time, place, motion, and knowing, which is what makes a headline feel like information rather than advertising. **Power words** set the *intensity* — they attach an emotional charge. Most of your headline should be context; the charge is seasoning.

Spend a charge budget by surface. From **Word Choice: Context and Power**: at the **ad**, use at most one moderate power word in an otherwise grounded line; at the **advertorial**, you may spend more freely, including the stronger vocabulary below; at the **jump page**, spend on certainty and safety words, not fear or hype.

Tier legend (power words only):

- ● ANY SURFACE **Any surface** — platform-safe and hype-safe, including cold ads.
- ● PRELANDER ONLY **Prelander only** — carries enough charge or claim-risk that it belongs on your advertorial/prelander pages, not in ad headlines that platforms review at their strictest.

Every word below is a full, usable word — drop it into a headline as-is. The lists are curated for headline duty from much larger source dictionaries (pointers at the end); if a word you love isn't here, it may simply have failed the "would this survive a cold feed?" test.

Context Words

Four groups. A note on the map: the source research groups these words into three families — time, insight, and a large "relativity" family covering where things are and how they move. For everyday use we split that third family into the two ways you'll actually

reach for it: **Space** and **Motion**.

Time — when it happens, how fast, what came before

now · today · tonight · tomorrow · yesterday · finally · suddenly · instantly · overnight · immediately · soon · early · late · never · always · again · before · after · until · while · during · once · first · last · next · new · old · ancient · modern · current · recent · daily · weekly · nightly · seasonal · annual · momentary · brief · quick · rapid · swift · slow · gradual · constant · endless · forever · deadline · countdown · era · decade · generation · lifetime · future · past · history · anniversary · morning · midnight · weekend · springtime · winter · prime · beginning · ending · eventually · already · anymore

Workhorses: **finally** (a backstory of waiting in one word), **overnight** (speed with a bed in it — concrete), **still** and **already** (quiet trend signals), **before/after** (the transformation frame in two words).

Space — where it is, where it hides

inside · outside · behind · beneath · beyond · under · over · above · below · between · beside · near · nearby · local · around · corner · edge · surface · deep · hidden (also a power word — see Fear) · buried · exposed · open · closed · doorstep · backyard · kitchen · garage · basement · attic · bedroom · office · desk · pocket · shelf · drawer · countertop · neighborhood · street · town · city · coast · border · everywhere · nowhere · home · indoors · outdoors · underground · offshore · overseas · frontier · territory · zone · room · wall · window · path · road · map · direction · north · miles · inches · distance · close · far · wide · narrow · high · low · center · middle · side · top · bottom

Workhorses: **inside** ("what's inside..." is a built-in curiosity frame), **hidden/buried** (space + mystery), **kitchen/garage/doorstep** (domestic locations make stories feel true and near), **local/nearby** (the local angle's engine — see **Finding Your Angle**).

Motion — what's moving, changing, spreading

switch · switching · drop · dropping · jump · turn · turning · shift · slash · cut · boost · lift · raise · lower · climb · fall · rise · surge · spread · spreading · sweep · sweeping · grow · growing · shrink · fade · vanish · disappear · quit · quitting · ditch · ditching · abandon · leave · leaving ·

return · comeback · move · moving · race · rush · flood · pour · flow · leak · slip · slide · roll · spin · flip · reverse · replace · replacing · swap · trade · trading · escape · break · breaking · launch · spark · trigger · accelerate · stall · stop · start · restart · push · pull · drive · steer · chase · catch · follow · lead · overtake · pass

Workhorses: **switching / ditching / trading** (a trend already in motion — "homeowners are switching..."), **slash/cut** (active-voice verbs for cost and effort), **spreading/sweeping** (social proof as weather), **quit** (a decision word that implies a story).

Insight — how the reader will come to know

why · how · what · which · who · discover · discovery · learn · realize · understand · know · knowing · find · found · reveal · revealed · uncover · uncovered · explain · explained · decode · truth · fact · facts · reason · reasons · answer · answers · question · clue · evidence · proof (also a power word — see Trust) · insight · lesson · rule · rules · law · principle · method · trick · technique · formula · blueprint · guide · secret (also a power word — see Curiosity/Desire) · mystery · myth · mistake (also a power word — see Fear) · misunderstood · overlooked · ignored · forgotten · surprising · unexpected · obvious · simple · plain · clear · honest · real · actual · exact · precise · think · rethink · wonder · notice · spot · recognize · admit · confess · finally-understood · sense · logic · meaning

Workhorses: **why** and **how** (the two most-used headline openers in history, because they frame the click as learning), **overlooked/ignored** (specific, low-hype curiosity), **truth/real/actual** (contrarian-angle fuel), **method/trick/formula** (mechanism-naming vocabulary — see **Curiosity: Withholding the How**).

Power Words

Grouped by the emotion they fire. Every word is tier-tagged. Remember the budget: one or two per headline, in a context-grounded sentence.

Fear & Warning — the protective click

The workhorse family of the whole palette. Warning vocabulary reads as public service, not sales — which is why it survives even cold feeds when used calmly.

● **ANY SURFACE** *mistake · mistakes · warning · beware · hidden · pitfall · pitfalls · trap · avoid · overlooked · risk · risky · caution · danger · dangerous · silent · quiet · costly · expensive-lesson · wrong · fail · failing · failure · lose · losing · loss · missing · missed · threat · vulnerable · exposed · fragile · broken · worn · fading · slipping · warning-signs · red-flag · blind-spot · gamble · backfire · regret*

● **PRELANDER ONLY** *scary · frightening · alarming · deadly · lethal · toxic · poison · nightmare · catastrophe · disaster · devastating · destroy · destroyed · ruin · ruined · wreak-havoc · plague · plagued · terrifying · horrifying · dread · panic · peril · hazardous · crippling · painful · agony · suffering · torture · trauma · collapse · crash · meltdown · epidemic · infested · contaminated · lurking · stalking · ambush · assault · attack · victim · targeted · scammed · swindled · blindsided · betrayed · backstabbed · corrupt · reckless · fatal · irreversible · point-of-no-return*

Curiosity & the Forbidden — the need to know

● **ANY SURFACE** *secret · secrets · surprising · unusual · odd · strange · weird · curious · little-known · rarely-seen · behind-the-scenes · insider · uncovered · revealed · untold · unspoken · quiet · unexpected · unlikely · mysterious · puzzling · counterintuitive · backwards · upside-down · myth · debunked · exposed*

● **PRELANDER ONLY** *forbidden · banned · censored · blacklisted · classified · confidential · off-limits · underground · black-market · smuggled · leaked · cover-up · hush-hush · illicit · outlawed · taboo · concealed · undercover · unauthorized · secret-society · lost · long-lost · elusive · cloak-and-dagger · under-the-table · behind-closed-doors · strings-attached · withheld · suppressed*

Desire & Aspiration — the life on the other side

● **ANY SURFACE** *free (use honestly — see the Do-Not-Use note on claim words) · effortless · easy · simple · smooth · comfortable · cozy · fresh · clean · bright · beautiful · elegant · timeless · classic · handcrafted · custom · personal · perfect-fit · dream · dreamy · ideal · satisfying · delightful · delicious · rich · abundant · thriving · flourishing · confident · proud · admired ·*

envied · respected · magnetic · charming · graceful · radiant · energized · renewed · restored · refreshed · youthful · vibrant · strong · sharp · focused · calm · peaceful · serene · freedom · independence

● **PRELANDER ONLY** *irresistible · seductive · alluring · captivating · spellbinding · mesmerizing · intoxicating · tantalizing · tempting · sinful · guilt-free · decadent · luxurious · lavish · opulent · exclusive · elite · VIP · first-class · five-star · millionaire · fortune · riches · wealth · jackpot · windfall · goldmine · lucrative · booming · skyrocket · soaring · unstoppable · limitless · legendary · iconic · coveted · prized · obsessed · addictive-to-read (describing content, never a product)*

Anger & Injustice — throwing rocks at the right enemies

Use sparingly, and aim only at problems, industries, and bad practices — never at people or protected groups. Injustice framing powers contrarian angles: *the system was the problem, not you.*

● **ANY SURFACE** *unfair · rigged-against-you · overpriced · overcharged · overrated · misleading · outdated · obsolete · broken-system · loophole · fine-print · middleman · markup · gimmick · gimmicks · racket · hassle · headache · nonsense · runaround · red-tape · fed-up · tired-of · sick-of · enough*

● **PRELANDER ONLY** *lies · lied-to · deceived · duped · fooled · cheated · robbed · ripped-off · exploited · gouged · fleeced · scandal · scandalous · outrage · outrageous · infuriating · greedy · crooked · shameless · brazen · cartel · monopoly · cover-up · sellout · stacked-deck · smoke-and-mirrors · snake-oil · propaganda · brainwashed*

Trust, Proof & Safety — the permission to believe

The jump page's home vocabulary (see **Believability and Proof**).

● **ANY SURFACE** *proven · proof · tested · verified · certified · documented · measured · studied · research-backed · evidence · track-record · trusted · reliable · dependable · consistent · genuine · authentic · honest · transparent · straightforward · no-nonsense · step-by-step · guided · backed · endorsed · recommended · established · time-tested · field-tested ·*

guaranteed (only with a real guarantee behind it) · refundable · risk-free (same rule) · secure · safe · protected · insured · lifetime · ironclad · no-strings · cancel-anytime · unconditional · official · accredited · professional · expert · specialist · veteran · master

● **PRELANDER ONLY** *bulletproof · foolproof · fail-safe · zero-risk · rock-solid · unbreakable · never-fails · sure-thing · can't-lose — this row borders on absolute claims; even on a prelander, attach them to the guarantee mechanics, never to results.*

Urgency & Scarcity — the cost of waiting

Honest urgency only: a real deadline, a real limit, a genuinely worsening problem.

Manufactured scarcity is a compliance and trust liability.

● **ANY SURFACE** *now · today · before-it's-too-late (only when literally true) · limited · closing · ending · expiring · last-chance · final · deadline · while-supplies-last · seasonal · window · running-out · don't-wait · act-soon · worsening · compounding · every-day-you-wait*

● **PRELANDER ONLY** *vanishing · disappearing-fast · almost-gone · doors-closing · never-again · once-in-a-lifetime · now-or-never · ticking-clock · eleventh-hour · brink · verge · critical · urgent · emergency*

✗ The Do-Not-Use Box

Words and families to keep out of headlines entirely — each with the one-line why.

Empty intensifiers — voltage with no content (the hype detector's training set):

- *amazing, incredible, unbelievable, awesome, stunning, mind-blowing* — claim excitement without information; readers discount them to zero and platforms read them as low-quality ad copy.
- *revolutionary, game-changing, disruptive, groundbreaking, cutting-edge, next-level* — every product claims these; the words now signal "advertisement" faster than they signal newness. Name the actual mechanism instead.

- *very, really, extremely, super, totally, absolutely, literally* — filler degree-words that weaken the word they modify; cut them and the sentence gets stronger.
- *SHOCKING, INSANE, CRAZY, EPIC* (and all-caps generally) — maximum-arousal styling triggers avoidance, not attention, and draws platform review like a magnet.

Compliance-trigger families — one bad word can kill an ad account:

- **Medical-claim words:** *cure, cures, heal, treats, reverses, eliminates [condition], clinically-proven* (without the actual clinical citation) — health claims are the most-policed category in advertising; imply support and management, never cure.
- **Absolute-outcome words:** *guaranteed results, never fails, works for everyone, 100%, permanent, instant results* — absolutes are both unbelievable and non-compliant; use qualified, specific, evidence-shaped claims (see **Believability and Proof**).
- **Income-promise words:** *get rich, make \$X guaranteed, passive income overnight, quit your job by [date]* — earnings claims face strict platform rules; results-vary reality must lead.
- **Fear-mongering-at-people words:** *you're dying, you will get [disease], everyone is lying to you* — personal negative predictions and paranoia framing violate most ad policies and poison trust.
- **Accusation words aimed at named parties:** *scam, fraud, criminal* pointed at a person or company — legal exposure plus platform rejection; aim anger vocabulary at practices and problems, never named targets.

LIWC-style noise — the source dictionaries are research word-lists, so they include function words (*when, while, till, ago*), inflection variants, and word-stems that were never meant for copy. Everything in this palette has already been expanded to full, headline-ready words; if you go back to the originals, expect to do that expansion and filtering yourself.

The full originals: this palette is a curation, not the complete inventory. The unabridged source dictionaries — the research-derived context-word dictionary (time / insight / relativity categories) and the full power-word compendium organized by

emotion — are kept alongside this series for anyone who wants to mine deeper. Bring back full words only, and run every find through the Do-Not-Use box above.

✓ Key Takeaways

- Draft first, palette second — this is a revision tool for swapping vague words for grounded ones and auditing your emotional charge.
- Context = environment (Time / Space / Motion / Insight); power = intensity (fear, curiosity, desire, anger, trust, urgency). Most of the headline should be context.
- Respect the tiers: ● ANY SURFACE words work anywhere; ● PRELANDER ONLY words belong on the prelander, never in platform-reviewed ad headlines.
- The fear-and-warning workhorses — *mistake, warning, beware, hidden, pitfall, trap, avoid, overlooked* — are the most reliably safe charge in the box.
- The Do-Not-Use box is absolute: empty intensifiers add nothing, and compliance-trigger families can cost you the account, not just the click.